

MEDITERRANEAN GALLEY

GALERA REAL

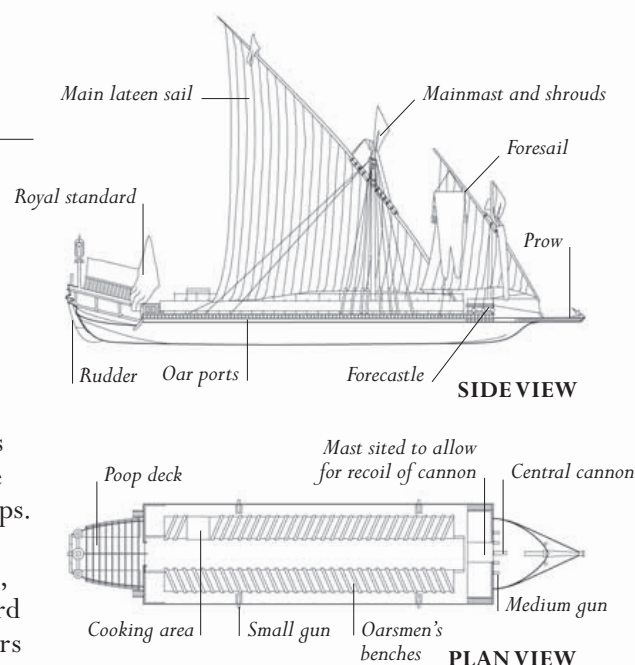
The *Galera Real* was no ordinary war galley but a luxury vessel made for Don John of Austria, commander of the Holy League fleet that defeated the Ottoman Turks at the Battle of Lepanto in 1571.

The ship carried up to 400 men, of which 236 rowed the galley, with four men per oar. In addition, there were a number of skilled sailors to steer and manage the two lateen sails, as well as a large detachment of soldiers, many of them armed with arquebuses. On the covered forecastle, beneath a raised fighting platform, the galley had a large central cannon and four medium-sized guns. Four small guns were sited among the oarsmen's stations, two on either side of the ship. In preparation

for Lepanto (see pp.154–55), the end of the prow, with its classical figurehead, was cut off so that the central cannon could be angled to shoot down on the Ottoman ships.

During the battle, the *Galera Real* was rammed by the Ottoman flagship *Sultana*, the enemy prow penetrating as far inboard as the innermost oarsman. Turkish soldiers boarded the galley but were driven back.

This replica of the *Galera Real* was made for Barcelona's Maritime Museum to mark the battle's 400th anniversary.



▲ GALERA REAL

The palatial royal flagship was 60m (197ft) long and 6.2m (20¼ft) wide. Sails were used on the open sea, but in battle the galley relied on its oarsmen.

AROUND THE SHIP



▲ AUXILIARY GUN

The small, breech-loading guns on either side of the galley could be swivelled on their mountings. They were loaded with small shot and used as anti-personnel weapons against the deck crew of an enemy galley.



▲ ORNATE SCUPPER

Small ports called scuppers were opened to let water run off the deck.

▲ DECK RANGE

One of the luxuries on Don John's galley was a range towards the stern. The cooking pots were suspended over the fire.

▲ REAR VIEW

The leading sculptors of Renaissance Spain created the statues and reliefs. Projecting from the deck beyond the stern is an outrigger, which supported the long oars.

